The Renter's Winter Kit

Six printable pages to protect your apartment through the cold months and protect your deposit when you move.

1. Winter Prep Checklist
2. Move-In Photo Log
3. Room-by-Room Inspection
4. Move-Out Deposit Checklist
5. Maintenance Request Log
6. Shutoffs & Emergency Map

Print what you need, fill it in by hand, and keep it with your lease. Snap a photo of each finished page as a backup.

Winter Prep Checklist

Work through this before the first freeze. Most of it takes under an hour, and none of it needs tools you don't own.

- [ ] **Find the main water shutoff** and test that you can turn it. Label it with tape.
- [ ] **Find the breaker panel.** Make sure the circuit labels are readable.
- [ ] **Test smoke and CO alarms.** Swap batteries if that's your job; report hardwired units that fail.
- [ ] **Replace the HVAC filter** if your lease makes it your job. Write the date on the frame.
- [ ] **Disconnect garden hoses** from outdoor spigots before the first freeze.
- [ ] **Freezing nights:** open cabinet doors under sinks on outside walls so warm air reaches the pipes.
- [ ] **Hard freezes:** let the faucets on outside walls drip slowly.
- [ ] **Away for the holidays?** Keep the heat on. Many guides say 55°F or higher.
- [ ] **Check windows and doors for drafts.** Use removable fixes (draft snakes, rope caulk) or ask before using adhesive.
- [ ] **Space heaters:** keep them 3 ft from anything that can burn, plug straight into the wall, and turn them off when you leave.
- [ ] **Report heating problems in writing now**, before the cold snap. Keep a copy.
- [ ] **Save the emergency maintenance number** in your phone, and check your renters insurance.

> Frozen pipe or water coming in? Shut off the main water valve first, then call emergency maintenance. Take photos as you go.

Move-In Photo Log

Photograph every existing scratch, stain and dent **before you unpack**. Log each photo here so you can find it at move-out.

Address _____ **Move-in date** _____

Room	Item / spot	Photo # or file name	Existing issue	Reported to landlord? (date)

Room-by-Room Inspection

Living room

Item	Good	Fair	Damaged	Notes
Walls & ceiling				
Floors / carpet				
Windows & screens				
Doors & locks				
Outlets & switches				
Lights / fixtures				

Kitchen

Item	Good	Fair	Damaged	Notes
Fridge & freezer				
Stove / oven / hood				
Dishwasher				
Sink & disposal				
Cabinets & counters				
Floor				

Bathroom

Item	Good	Fair	Damaged	Notes
Toilet (flush, base)				
Tub / shower & caulk				
Sink & faucet				
Exhaust fan				
Hot water & pressure				
Mirror / cabinet				

Bedroom(s)

Item	Good	Fair	Damaged	Notes
Walls & ceiling				
Floors / carpet				
Closet & doors				
Windows & blinds				
Outlets & lights				
Smoke alarm				

Tenant signature / date _____ **Landlord signature / date** _____

Move-Out Deposit Checklist

Your move-in log from pages 2–3 is your best evidence. Start this list 30 days before you move.

- [ ] **Give written notice** by the deadline in your lease. Keep a copy.
- [ ] **Give your forwarding address in writing** so your deposit and any itemized deductions can reach you.
- [ ] **Ask for a walk-through** and attend if you can.
- [ ] **Deep clean:** inside the oven and fridge, bathroom grout, baseboards, window tracks, floors.
- [ ] **Small fixes** (nail holes, bulbs, loose handles), only where your lease allows tenant repairs.
- [ ] **Remove everything:** belongings, trash and anything left in storage, garage or mailbox.
- [ ] **Photograph every room after cleaning** from the same angles as your move-in photos.
- [ ] **Record final meter readings** and schedule your utility shutoffs or transfers.
- [ ] **Return every key, fob and remote.** Get a receipt or send a dated email confirming it.
- [ ] **Look up your state's deposit-return deadline** and write it below.

Notice given (date + how) _____

Walk-through date _____

Keys returned (date + to whom) _____

Deposit amount _____ **State return deadline** _____

Deposit received (date + amount) _____

Maintenance Request Log

Report problems in writing (portal, email or text) and log them here. A dated record helps if a problem comes back or a deposit question comes up.

Date reported	Issue	How reported	Ref # / who	Response date	Fixed date	Notes

Shutoffs & Emergency Map

Fill this in on move-in day and stick it inside a kitchen cabinet door. In an emergency nobody wants to go hunting.

Where things are

Main water shutoff _____

Water heater + its shutoff _____

Breaker panel _____

Gas meter / shutoff (if any) _____

Fire extinguisher _____

HVAC filter (size) _____

Who to call

Emergency maintenance _____

Landlord / manager _____

Electric utility _____

Gas utility _____

Renters insurance + policy # _____

Breaker labels

#	Controls
1	
2	
3	
4	
5	
6	
7	
8	
9	
10	
11	
12	
13	
14	
15	
16	

Smell gas? Don't flip switches or use flames. Leave first, then call your gas utility or 911 from outside.